

# The job is finding a photo you still picture — not a better search box

People start with a fragment of memory. Success is opening the photo they meant. Faster indexing or a smarter keyword rank is a different product.

## North-star metric • OUR BET

Successful vague-memory retrieval rate = users who find the intended photo on a vague-memory task ÷ users who start a search with incomplete memory.

## Out of scope

Search latency, ranking of exact keywords, and "make search feel faster."

- METRIC DECOMPOSITION

# That number only moves if Photos understands the clue the person still has

One bet. The other steps stay healthy; they are not a second product.

## Formulate

Turn incomplete memory into a starting clue.

## Understand · OUR BET

Accept vibe, object, or episode — not a date first.

## Retrieve

Target in the first grouped set.

## Recognize

The person opens the intended photo.

## Refine

"More like this" or "not this trip."

*Sub-metrics: formulation rate, clue-understanding rate, candidate coverage, recognition rate, refinement success, workaround-scroll rate, known-item control success.*

Bet labeled in words, not by colour alone

## Public voice becomes ranked retrieval problems — not a sentiment dashboard

1

### Listen

Public photo talk: stores, forums, community posts.

2

### Keep

Stories about a failed find. Drop storage and star-rating noise.

3

### Group

Themes that share at least two real quotes.

4

### Score

Impact, feasibility, and how often it appears.

5

### Drop

"Search is slow" is not this job.

*Research questions (Q1–Q10): photo kinds struggle, remembered vs forgotten cues, formulation methods, where search breaks, workarounds, evaluable vs overwhelming results, refinement behavior, segment differences.*

• OPPORTUNITY RANKING (PHASE 2)

Place without a name is the first problem we will solve.  
Generic search we refused.

People remember how a café felt and have forgotten the town.

| Opportunity             | Impact | Feasibility | Frequency | Node         |
|-------------------------|--------|-------------|-----------|--------------|
| Place-vibe without name | High   | High        | High      | Understand   |
| Generic search latency  | High   | High        | High      | Out of scope |
| Object + episode        | Medium | Medium      | Medium    | Understand   |

Phase 2 decision: PlaceVibeWithoutName · Metric node: understand · Interview segment: S2 trip/event rememberer · readyForPhase3: true

## Six in-segment interviews validated the hypothesis before we built

### Method

Google Form G1–G9. 30 min protocol. Reconstruct one failed find until memory is specific.

### Screeners

Photos  $\geq 12$  months. Library large enough that scrolling is not default. Can recall at least one remembered-but-unfound photo. Matches S2.

### Protocol

Recover: retrieval task, remembered cues, forgotten cues, query typed, Photos response, workaround, recognizability, next attempt.

*Form: <https://forms.gle/wvQ3pQVQLhxMDFTm9> · Responses: 6 submitted, 6 in-segment S2 · Known-item excluded*

• VALIDATION RESULTS (PHASE 3)

Place-vibe confirmed. Forgotten date/album confirmed.  
Generic search not supported.

| Phase 1 theme              | vs form       | Node         | Note                                                                         |
|----------------------------|---------------|--------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Place-vibe without name    | Confirmed     | Understand   | G4/G5 trip/place vibe; G6 place-felt/trip; G8 take vibe or trip without town |
| Forgotten date/album       | Confirmed     | Formulate    | Forgotten cue confirmed. Product bet stays understand, not formulate         |
| Timeline scroll workaround | Confirmed     | Refine       | G9: scroll, ask a person, another app, or still unfound                      |
| Generic search latency     | Not supported | Out of scope | Form asks memory, not speed. Out of brief scope                              |

- PROBLEM DEFINITION (PHASE 4)

## People remember how a place felt on a trip and have forgotten the date, album, and town name

### Target segment

S2 Trip/event rememberer.  
Large library. Remembers trip by  
vibe (café, lights, boat).  
Forgotten date, album, town  
name.

### Retrieval scenario

The café I cannot date — a trip  
photo the person can still  
picture when capture day and  
place name are gone.

### Product outcome · OUR BET

Understand — the product  
accepts vibe, object, episode,  
and fuzzy time. Exactly one  
node.

*Root cause: Search cannot take the clue they still have even though the photo is in the library. Workarounds: scroll, ask a person, another app, still unfound. Business value: library people cannot re-enter becomes write-only backup.*

## Remember puts intelligence at the moment of understanding: a vibe in, a trip group out

1

### Offer a fragment

Type or speak what is left. Never a date first.

2

### See a trip group

Photos groups the trip and says why this set.

3

### Confirm or steer

Open the photo, or say "not this trip."

Keyword Search stays the control. Remember is a different path — not a second search box. Intelligence at understand (place-vibe language → grouped candidates).

- MVP TESTING RESULTS (PHASE 6)

## Three return sessions found the café, the trip, and the gig. Keep grouping by trip.

### What worked (n=3)

t01: keyword miss, Remember success on task-go-a-cafe.

t02: keyword miss, Remember success on task-go-a-trip.

t03: keyword miss, Remember success on task-concert-lights.

### What to change next · OUR BET

Keep trip grouping with near-miss Europe café. Place-name clue still has to group by trip. Keep vibe-language grouping (lights/gig) and never ask venue or date first.

*Gates passed: n-return-users=3, in-segment=S2, retrieval-task used, baseline attempted, next-iteration named, phase4-lock, phase5-mvp.  
Prototype library — not their Google Photos account.*

- **SUCCESS METRICS & RISKS (PHASES 7-8)**

## We will know it worked when more of these searches end on the right photo

### Leading metrics

- Clue submitted as memory language (without date first)
- MemoryQuery holds the locked cue type (placeVibe, object, episode, fuzzy time)
- Target in the first grouped set
- Target opened from a group
- Success after refine

### Risks & mitigations

- Read as "better search" → composer asks for fragment, not "Search your photos"
- Model invents date/town → ground MemoryQuery in typed tokens; strip assistantText matching date/GPS patterns
- Learned café task success → use respondent's Phase 3 task when original photo can be used

*Guardrails: control date, task still succeeds in Search; hallucinated EXIF rate stays at zero. Prototype signals only — not Google Ph*  
Three risks, each with a mitigation  
*production telemetry.*